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THE FINAL TEST

Thanks to the early finish at Kolkata, I spent two quiet days at home before rejoining my team-mates. I made the most of the time to myself ahead of all the frenzy. The only cricket I played was with my son in our back yard, when he tried to test me out with some short-pitched stuff – with a tennis ball. It was great just to have some fun with him.

On 11 November, I met up with the rest of the team on the Mumbai Sea Link on our way to Kandivali Gymkhana, which was being renamed after me in a function organized by the Mumbai Cricket Association. It was a great honour. It is an excellent facility and I hope it will serve as a breeding ground for young talent in the region.

When we eventually got to the Taj Mahal Palace hotel, I couldn't believe the lengths they had gone to. My pictures were in all the lifts and on the nineteenth floor, where the team was staying, there were photographs on every wall. In my own room every little thing you could think of was personalized. From the soaps and shampoos to the pillow covers, everything had my name on it, and every day the Taj management sent me a personalized sweet of some kind, such as cake or chocolate.

I was busy sorting things out in my room when I got a call from our coach, Duncan Fletcher. He said the team wanted to honour me by wearing special shirts that said 'Sachin Ramesh Tendulkar – 200th Test match', and he asked if I had any problems with this. I said it was an absolute privilege and I was overwhelmed.

There was no doubt that this would be a Test match like no other. There was a huge media presence everywhere, bigger than ever before.